

EUROPEAN WILDLIFE

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EUROPE IS A landmass that contains many different habitats, ranging from the Arctic tundra, through broad-leaved forests, and mountainous areas, to dry, hot regions around the Mediterranean. Only deserts and tropical forests are missing from the list. European wildlife is not as rich as it once was; human intervention in the form of agriculture and forest clearance, as well as the sheer size of the human population, has diminished the number of plants and animals. Yet in undisturbed forests and wetlands, a large diversity of wildlife remains.

Broad-leaved woodland wildlife

Broad-leaved woodlands extend across Europe. The trees within them, such as oaks and sycamores, are broad-leaved, or deciduous, trees, which means they lose their leaves in winter. In spring and summer, when the leaves reappear and plants bloom, woodlands support many insects, birds, and mammals, such as squirrels and mice.



Dappled coats help to camouflage deer as they graze on grass.



Red fox

Red foxes live on their own or in small family groups in underground dens. They are most active at night when they hunt for rabbits, rodents, and worms. They may also eat fish and fruit.

Fallow deer

Woodland provides cover and food for fallow deer. Females and young live in small herds. Males have antlers, and are solitary or live in small groups. Males and females meet during the mating season in the autumn.

Oak tree

Commonly found in broad-leaved woodlands, oaks provide homes and food for many animals. Insects, for example, feed on leaves and other parts of the tree, while they themselves are food for larger animals, such as birds. Acorns, the fruits of the oak, appear in late summer.



Once acorns have fallen to the ground, they provide a nutritious meal for birds, squirrels, and mice.

Female nut weevil drilling into acorn with her mouthparts.

Rostrum

Nut weevil

This beetle lives on oak trees, feeding on buds and leaves. It has a snout-like rostrum, at the end of which are its jaws. In late summer, the female makes holes in the oak's acorns. In each hole she deposits an egg. The larva that hatches from the egg feeds on the acorn.

Females flick their large, bushy tails to warn cubs of danger.



Bulrushes provide nesting sites for birds.



Flower head

Bulrushes

These tall grass-like plants grow at the fringes of lakes and ponds. Their roots are often in wet soil or submerged in water, while their stems and leaves extend above the water. Bulrushes have dark, compact, cylindrical flower heads.

European kingfisher

This small bird hunts for fish and other water animals from a perch along the banks of streams and lakes. Once prey is spotted, the kingfisher plunges into the water, grabs it with its long, pointed beak, and returns to the perch to eat its meal.

Wetland wildlife

Europe's wetlands are rich in wildlife. Reeds, bulrushes, and marsh plants provide food and shelter for wetland animals, such as voles and otters. Insects and other invertebrates are a food source for fish and frogs, which themselves are eaten by many water birds.



European otter

Otters are strong swimmers, adapted for rapid movement in water. An otter's body is long and streamlined, its dense, glossy fur is water-repellent, and it has webbed feet. Otters hunt underwater, catching prey such as fish, water birds, and frogs. They are equally agile on land, and catch water voles and other animals that live on riverbanks.

Water vole

Water voles are good swimmers. They build tunnels in banks next to lakes and slow-moving rivers. These tunnels have chambers for food storage and nesting, and entrances that open above and below the waterline.

Water voles feed on plants, roots, and bulbs.



Edible frog

Edible frogs live in marshes and lakes, sometimes emerging at night to feed on land. They catch insects with their long, sticky tongues. Larger prey, such as newts and small fish, are caught in the jaws and pushed into the mouth with the feet.